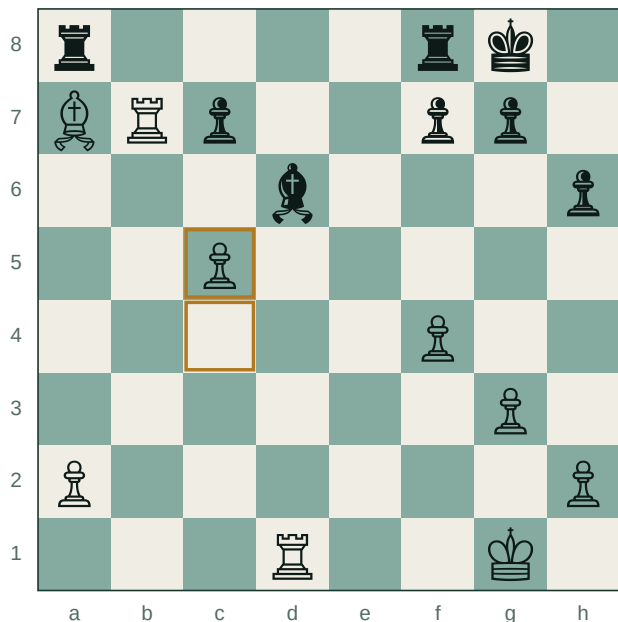


Capture the defender: Black, move 23

Capture the defender

Black to move



Previous move: 23.c5. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

23...Rxa7 24. Rxa7 Bxc5+ 25. Kf1 Bxa7

23...Rxa7 The rook captures the bishop on a7. Recorded reply: **24.Rxa7**.

24...Bxc5+ Check restricts White to 4 legal replies here. From c5 it attacks king on g1 and rook on a7. Recorded reply: **25.Kf1**.

25...Bxa7 The bishop captures the rook on a7.

At the end, nominal material is White 9 / Black 12 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +4. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +4: the balance goes from -1 to +3. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

Do not assume a defender is unique. Another piece may take over its job, or the opponent may decline to recapture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

Removing a key defender can transform a protected square into a winning entry. The defender's function explains why the first capture matters.

HOW TO LOOK

Identify the protected target, capture its essential defender, and calculate the follow-up after each plausible recapture.

The defending king is on g1. Geometrically undefended: rook on b7 and rook on d1. Check for tactical protection.